

SG #10 — Isaiah 18–23

Oracle Against Foreign Nations (OAFN)

- Five doctrinal teachings of the OAFN:
 1. Sovereignty
 2. Divine Judgement
 3. Accountability
 4. Comfort and Restoration
 5. Punishment

Egypt as Symbol

- What Egypt was known for anciently: Military power, advanced civilization, agriculture (Nile), wisdom and magic, great wealth; Israel repeatedly looked to Egypt for political alliance
- Egypt as a **type of the world**: Represents worldly power, pride, and trust in human strength rather than God — "Egypt is man, not God; their horses are flesh, not spirit" (Isa 31:3)
- Egypt as a **type of refuge/deliverance from enemies**: Israel repeatedly fled to Egypt — Abraham, Joseph, Jacob's family, Jeroboam, and even the young Jesus — a pattern of seeking physical safety in Egypt; yet it is ultimately a false refuge that disappoints when the Lord is not the foundation of trust
- Egypt in LDS heritage: The Book of Abraham (papyri from Egypt); Joseph of Egypt's prophecies in the Book of Mormon; reformed Egyptian as the script of the gold plates

Isaiah 18 — Two Interpretations

- Historical interpretation: A prophecy addressed to Ethiopia/Cush (ancient Nubia/Sudan), warning against trusting Egypt-Ethiopia as a military alliance against Assyria
- LDS interpretation: The "strange land" is America — the land from which missionaries are sent forth to gather Israel in the last days

Isaiah 19:18–25 — Restoration and Conversion of Egypt

- Five elements of the restoration/conversion of Egypt:
 6. Speak Hebrew (the covenant language — 19:18)
 7. Temple — an altar to the Lord in the midst of Egypt (19:19)
 8. A Savior sent to deliver them (19:20)
 9. Egypt healed — the Lord will smite and heal (19:22)
 10. A highway from Egypt to Assyria — former enemies united (19:23)
- What the promise of an altar signifies: A temple — the full covenant worship of the Lord established in Egypt
- Promised future relationship (Lord, Assyria, Egypt, Israel): "Israel shall be the third with Egypt and with Assyria" — all three will be a blessing in the midst of the earth; former enemies united under the Lord (19:24–25)

Isaiah 20:2–4

- What Isaiah was told to do for three years: Walk naked (without outer garment) and barefoot — a public prophetic sign act lasting three years
- What it signified: Just as Isaiah walked stripped and barefoot, so the King of Assyria would lead away Egyptian and Ethiopian captives naked, barefoot, and with buttocks uncovered — a warning not to trust Egypt as an ally

Isaiah 22:1–14 — Prophecy About Judah

- What is prophesied: Jerusalem celebrates and feasts rather than weeping and repenting in the face of coming destruction; the people trust in weapons and walls rather than the Lord; their sin will not be purged ("this iniquity shall not be purged from you till ye die")
- Two possible fulfillments:
 1. The Assyrian siege of Jerusalem under Sennacherib (701 BC) — city was threatened and survived
 2. The Babylonian destruction of Jerusalem (586 BC) — the ultimate fulfillment of the unrepentant city's doom

Isaiah 22:15–25 — Shebna and Eliakim

- Who Shebna is: The royal steward (treasurer) in Hezekiah's court; he is proud and has hewn out a tomb for himself in the rock; he will be removed from office, rolled up like a ball, and cast into a foreign land
- Who Eliakim is: Son of Hilkiah; will replace Shebna as steward; will be a faithful father to the inhabitants of Jerusalem
- Symbols suggesting Eliakim as **type of Christ**:
 - Given the *key of the house of David* (cf. Rev 3:7 — "these things saith he that hath the key of David")
 - What he opens, no one shuts; what he shuts, no one opens
 - Called "a father to the inhabitants of Jerusalem" — Christ as Eternal Father
 - "A nail fastened in a sure place" — sure foundation
- The Davidic covenant language and "**a nail in a sure place**": A peg/nail driven firmly into a wall, on which all the vessels (glory) of his father's house shall hang — all blessings and glory depend on this sure foundation; Christ is the nail on which all covenantal promises hang
- Difference between Eliakim and Christ: Eliakim ultimately fails — the nail is "cut down and fall" (22:25); Christ never fails; Eliakim is a type pointing forward to the One who is truly sure

Application — Foreign Nations Today

- Things we should **KNOW** about foreign nations: The Church's reach is global and the Lord cares about all people of all nations; humanitarian aid from the Church is intended to bless the entire world 📌 See slides for Bishop McMullin and President Nelson's specific points
- Three things we can **DO** (Bishop McMullin & President Nelson): 📌 See slides

SG #11 — Isaiah 24–27

Key Definitions

Term	Definition
Seer	One who sees — a prophet with the gift of seeing hidden/future things by revelation (Mosiah 8:15–17: "a seer is greater than a prophet") 📌 Confirm with slides
Apocalypse	Genre of revelation; from Greek/Hebrew meaning "from hidden" — an unveiling of hidden divine realities
Apocalyptic	A style/genre of writing characterized by cosmic scope, symbolic imagery, divine intervention, and focus on the final victory of good over evil 📌 Confirm with slides

Eschatological	Teaching about last things — death, judgment, resurrection, Second Coming, Millennium, new creation
New Creation	Begins with the Millennium and ends with the Celestial Kingdom; the creation of a new, glorified world — the full reversal of the Fall

Apocalyptic Writing

- Themes and characteristics: Cosmic end of the world, divine intervention, final victory of good over evil, heavy use of symbolism; also: heavenly visions, dualism, and hope for the faithful amid crisis
- How Isaiah 24–27 fits with the preceding chapters: Isaiah 13–23 contains oracles against specific foreign nations (Babylon, Assyria, Egypt, etc.); Isaiah 24–27 ("Isaiah's Apocalypse") expands the scope from particular nations to the whole earth — a cosmic conclusion to the judgment section, moving from the particular to the universal

Isaiah 24 — The Earth Laid Waste

- What will happen, to whom, why, how, and where: The entire earth will be emptied and made waste (*to whom*: all people equally — priest and people, servant and master, buyer and seller); (*why*.) because they have transgressed the laws, changed the ordinances, and broken the everlasting covenant; (*how*.) the Lord will punish the host of heaven and kings of the earth; (*where*.) upon the whole face of the earth, then they are gathered into the pit
- **24:1–6**: The imagery is the *reverse of creation* — the undoing of the ordered world God made; chaos returns; like going back to the *tohu wa-bohu* of Genesis 1:2
- **24:5** — "Changed the ordinance" / "broken the everlasting covenant": The people have violated the divine laws and sacred ordinances God established; this is not merely civil law but covenant law
 - Where found in D&C: D&C 1:15 — "they have strayed from mine ordinances, and have broken mine everlasting covenant"
- **24:21–22** — Who will be punished and where: The "host of the high ones" (wicked spiritual beings/fallen angels) and the kings of the earth will be gathered as prisoners in a pit (spirit prison); they will be shut up and after many days visited/judged

Isaiah 25 — Song of Praise

- What this chapter is celebrating/praising: The Lord's victory over death, his destruction of the "covering" of mourning over all nations, his provision of a great feast for all peoples, and the ultimate comfort of his people
- **25:6** — Symbolism of eating together: A covenant meal; table fellowship = unity, acceptance, belonging; eating together in the ancient Near East was a binding act of covenant and kinship
- **Messianic Banquet** (Isa 25:6–8; Matt 22:1–14; Lk 14:11–14; D&C 58:8–12):
 - Meaning: The feast of "fat things" and "wines on the lees well refined" = the celestial blessings of the kingdom of God, freely offered to all peoples
 - Symbolism of the Wedding Feast: Christ is the Bridegroom; his people (the church/Israel) are the bride; the wedding feast = the fullness of the covenant relationship consummated at the Second Coming
 - Who is invited / who will come: All peoples of all nations are invited; those who accept the invitation and come in the proper way (i.e., have on the wedding garment = the Atonement) are welcomed; those who refuse or are unprepared are excluded
 - What early Christians celebrated: The Eucharist/sacrament — understood as an anticipatory participation in the Messianic Banquet and a remembrance of the Last Supper

- **25:8** — What Jesus gains victory over: Death — "He will swallow up death in victory" (cf. 1 Cor 15:54); death is itself consumed/destroyed
- "Wipe away tears from off all faces": Ultimate comfort; the end of mourning, sorrow, and suffering through the Resurrection and the healing of all losses; personal, individual comfort from God
- Who will be resurrected: All people — universal resurrection (though the timing and nature differ); death is overcome for all

Isaiah 27 — Leviathan and the Vineyard

- **27:1** — Leviathan: The ancient sea monster of Canaanite mythology symbolizing chaos, evil, and the power of the sea/the adversary; saying the Lord will destroy Leviathan means the Lord will ultimately defeat Satan and all forces of evil/chaos
- **27:2–6** — Similar and different from Song of the Vineyard (Isa 5):
 - Similar: Israel is the vineyard; the Lord planted it; the metaphor drives the message
 - Different: In Isa 5, the vineyard is condemned — it produced wild grapes and will be abandoned; in Isa 27, the Lord tends it carefully, waters it every moment, keeps it night and day — it is redemptive rather than condemnatory
 - What it means that the vineyard bears fruit: Israel fulfills its covenant mission; it fills the world with righteousness and is a blessing to all nations (cf. the Abrahamic covenant)
- **27:12–13** — Imagery of the gathering of Israel:
 - The Lord will thresh from the river (Euphrates) to the stream of Egypt, gathering Israel grain by grain
 - A great trumpet will be blown; those scattered in Assyria and Egypt will return and worship the Lord in Jerusalem
 - Gathered "one by one": The gathering is personal and individual — the Lord knows each soul; it is not a mass anonymous movement but an individual covenant relationship

Application

- Nibley's story about the Apocalyptic View: 📌 *See slides*
- The proper power of reading prophecies of world destruction: Rather than causing fear or despair, they should motivate repentance and trust in the Lord; the righteous need not fear; these prophecies exist to warn and invite, not to terrify the faithful
- Elder Oaks on preparation for the Second Coming: We should not try to set dates or identify signs obsessively; rather, we should live righteously as if the Second Coming could be soon, focusing on what we can control (personal righteousness, temple covenants, family, missionary work) 📌 *See slides for exact content*
- Elder Holland on our dispensation's unique responsibility: Our dispensation has more light, more scripture, more priesthood authority, and more opportunity than any other; we have a responsibility no other dispensation has had — to take the gospel to every nation and prepare the earth for the Second Coming 📌 *See slides for exact quote*

SG #12 — The Book of Mormon and Isaiah (2 Nephi 25–30)

Joseph Smith and Isaiah

- Occasion when Joseph Smith was first introduced to Isaiah's prophecies: When Moroni visited Joseph Smith on the night of September 21–22, 1823; Moroni quoted Isaiah 11 (the root of Jesse) and Isaiah 29 (the sealed book/marvelous work) among other passages, explaining they were about to be fulfilled
- Five categories of things Joseph was being instructed in: 📌 *See slides — likely includes: (1) the Apostasy and Restoration, (2) the gathering of Israel, (3) the coming forth of the Book of Mormon, (4) the role of Elijah/temple work, (5) the Second Coming/last days*

- Number of complete Isaiah chapters in the Book of Mormon: **21 complete chapters**

Benefits of a Second Copy of Isaiah in the BOM

1. Provides textual variants that help clarify translation difficulties in the Hebrew/KJV (e.g., 1 Ne 20–21 differs meaningfully from Isa 48–49)
2. Provides interpretive/prophetic commentary through Nephi, Jacob, and others that illuminates the meaning of Isaiah's words
3. Establishes that Isaiah's writings (including chapters attributed to "Second Isaiah") existed before 600 BC, supporting single authorship and the antiquity of the record

Prophetic Commentary — Three Examples

1. Nephi quotes Isaiah 48–49 (1 Ne 20–21) and then immediately interprets them in 1 Ne 22 — applying them to the scattering and gathering of Israel
2. Nephi quotes Isaiah 2–14 in 2 Ne 12–24 and then provides an extended interpretive commentary in 2 Ne 25–30
3. Nephi rewrites/likens Isaiah 29 in 2 Ne 27, applying it directly to the coming forth of the Book of Mormon

Welch's Nephite Prophetic View

- Definition: A framework showing that Nephite prophets understood their own history and the history of all Israel through a recurring four-stage prophetic pattern derived from Isaiah
- Four stages:
 1. **Christ's coming** — the first coming of the Messiah
 2. **Rejection of Christ / Scattering of Jews** — Israel rejects Christ and is scattered
 3. **Gathering of Israel** — the Day of the Gentiles; the gospel goes to the Gentiles who then carry it to Israel
 4. **Restoration of Israel** — Israel is fully restored, gathers, and accepts Christ
- How Nephi uses Isaiah in this model: Nephi quotes Isaiah chapters that speak to all four stages and maps them onto his own people's experience — they have left Jerusalem (destruction/exile), will be scattered (scattering), and will eventually be gathered through the Book of Mormon (restoration/fulfillment)
- How the NPV explains which Isaiah chapters are included in the BOM: Nephi selects Isaiah passages that collectively cover the entire prophetic arc his people are living through; they are not random selections but a carefully chosen set that teaches the full pattern of Israel's destiny

Key Terms

- "Gentile" according to Elder McConkie: Not descended from Judah; more broadly, those outside the covenant house of Israel; in the latter-day context, includes many who have Israelite blood but have lost their covenant identity
- The Day of the Gentile: The period in the last days when the gospel goes primarily to the Gentile nations before returning to Israel and the Jews; we are currently in the Day of the Gentile; it will eventually end and "the times of the Gentiles" will be fulfilled

Why Nephi Quotes Isaiah 2–14 in One Continuous Stretch (Welch, p. 123)

To supply Isaiah as a **third witness** — in addition to Nephi and Jacob — to the truths being taught; these chapters together cover the complete prophetic arc Nephi wants his descendants to understand  See Welch p. 123 for full argument

2 Nephi 25–30 — Three Groups in Nephi's Prophecy

- The three groups and how each reflects the four stages:
 5. **Jews:** (1) Destroyed — Jerusalem destroyed, scattered; (2) Exiled — scattered for rejecting Christ; (3) Restored — will eventually accept Christ in the latter days; (4) Fulfilled — gathered to their land and into the covenant
 6. **Lamanites:** (1) Destruction of Nephites prophesied; (2) Scattered and lose their identity/gospel knowledge; (3) Restored through the Book of Mormon which will make them "blossom as the rose"; (4) Fulfilled — become "a pure and delightsome people"
 7. **Gentiles:** (1) Have a day of great power/opportunity; (2) Sin/reject fullness; (3) Restored if they repent and join Israel; (4) Either gathered into Israel or swept away — the choice is theirs

Chapter Topics (2 Nephi 26–29)

Chapter	Topic
2 Ne 26	Sins of the Gentiles in the last days; Christ's ministry among the Nephites; destruction of the Nephites
2 Ne 27	Likening Isaiah 29 to the BOM — "voice from the dust"; the marvelous work and a wonder
2 Ne 28	The Apostasy — false churches, false doctrines, the devil's strategy in the last days
2 Ne 29	Many Gentiles reject the Book of Mormon ("we have a Bible"); the Lord's answer; three sets of records

Six Sins of the Gentiles (2 Nephi 28)

1. Pride
2. Grind upon the face of the poor
3. Secret combinations
4. Priestcraft
5. Iniquity (breaking the 10 commandments)
6. Deny the power of God
 - Which are typical of Isaiah: Pride and false religion/empty worship (Isa 29:13); rejection of the prophets' word

2 Nephi 27 — The Marvelous Work and a Wonder

- What happens in this chapter: Nephi likens Isaiah 29 to the latter days; the "voice from the dust" = the Book of Mormon speaking from the earth; the **marvelous work and a wonder = the Restoration + the coming forth of the Book of Mormon**; a sealed book is delivered; God confounds the learned (Charles Anthon) and enables the unlearned (Joseph Smith) to translate by divine power

2 Nephi 29:11–13 — Three Sets of Records

1. The Bible — the record of the Jews, containing the word of God given to Israel in the eastern hemisphere
2. The Book of Mormon — the record of the Nephites/Lamanites, containing the word of God given to Israel in the western hemisphere
3. The records of the lost ten tribes — yet to come forth; "I shall also speak unto the other tribes of the house of Israel"

Scattering and Gathering of Israel

Group	Land	Identity	Christ
Jews	Scattered from Israel; return to Israel in the latter days	Lost national/covenant identity in diaspora; restored through the gathering	Will accept Christ in the last days (Zech 12:10; D&C 45:51–53)
Nephites	Removed from the promised land through destruction	Identity preserved in the Book of Mormon record	The Book of Mormon testifies of Christ to their descendants
Gentiles	No specific covenant land initially; gather to Zion/Stakes	Adopt the identity of Israel through conversion and covenant	Accept Christ and carry the gospel to Israel

- Key dates and what each represents:
 - **722 BC**: Assyria destroys the Northern Kingdom (Samaria); 10 tribes scattered
 - **600 BC**: Lehi leaves Jerusalem; beginning of the Lehi/Nephite record
 - **586 BC**: Babylon destroys Jerusalem; Judah scattered into exile
 - **539 BC**: Cyrus the Great conquers Babylon; issues decree allowing Jews to return
 - **AD 70**: Rome destroys Jerusalem and the temple under Titus; Jews scattered for ~1900 years
 - **1830**: Organization of the Church; beginning of the formal gathering of Israel in the last days

2 Nephi 30:2–7 — The Gathering

- Gathering of the Gentiles: Those who repent and are baptized are grafted into the covenant and numbered among the house of Israel; they are no longer Gentiles but become Israel
- Gathering of the Lamanites: The Book of Mormon will restore their knowledge of their identity as a remnant of Israel; "scales of darkness shall begin to fall from their eyes" and they will "blossom as the rose"
- Gathering of the Jews: They will come to believe in Christ — "believe in the Messiah, that he is the Son of God" — and be gathered to their lands of inheritance

SG #13 — Isaiah 28–29

Isaiah 28 — To Ephraim and Judah

- To whom addressed / their sins: Addressed first to **Ephraim** (Northern Kingdom, 28:1–4) — drunk with wine, proud of their fading glory; then to **Judah** (28:14ff) — mocking the prophets, making a "covenant with death" by trusting in foreign alliances and lies instead of the Lord

Isaiah 28:9–13 / 2 Ne. 28:30 — Spiritual Progression

- The principle Isaiah teaches: Spiritual knowledge is given incrementally — "precept upon precept, line upon line, here a little, there a little" — the Lord teaches gradually, building upon what has already been received
- What it means for those who refuse: For those who reject the word, this same pattern becomes their stumbling block — they go forward and fall backward, are snared and broken; receiving no more, they lose what they have (cf. D&C 50:24)

- Elder Bednar's teaching:  See slides — *general principle: we must act on the light we receive to receive more; the Spirit teaches incrementally; those who are faithful in small things receive greater things*

Isaiah 28:14–19 — Covenant of Death and the Cornerstone

- Meaning of the covenant of death: Judah's political alliance with Egypt — trusting in lies and falsehood to protect them from the "overflowing scourge" (the Assyrian/Babylonian invasion); they think human alliances can protect them from judgment
- Meaning of the scourge: The Assyrian/Babylonian military invasion — "the overflowing scourge shall pass through"
- Meaning of the cornerstone: Jesus Christ — "a tried stone, a precious corner stone, a sure foundation"; he who believes in the cornerstone will not make haste (panic); everything else is built upon him (cf. 1 Pet 2:6; Eph 2:20)
- **Psalm 118:22–29 / Matt. 21:9, 42–46** — what they teach about the cornerstone: "The stone which the builders rejected is become the head of the corner" — Jesus applied this to himself when speaking to the chief priests; the leaders of Israel rejected him, but God made him the cornerstone; those who fall on this stone will be broken, and on whomever it falls, it will grind to powder
- What Jews sing at the Feast of Tabernacles: "Hosanna!" (Hebrew: *hoshia na* = "save now") from Psalm 118:25 — a cry of salvation associated with the Messiah's coming; also sung while waving palm/willow branches
- What Christians sing on Palm Sunday: "Hosanna! Blessed is he that cometh in the name of the Lord" (Ps 118:26; Matt 21:9) — the crowds greeted Jesus with this cry, consciously welcoming the Messianic King; both traditions echo the cornerstone/salvation language of Isaiah 28 and Psalm 118

Isaiah 28:24–29 — Farming Parable

- What the farming parable teaches: A wise farmer does not plow endlessly — he prepares the ground, then plants different crops using different methods appropriate to each; God's dealings with his people are similarly purposeful, varied, and wise — he knows exactly what he is doing even when his methods seem harsh or unusual; his wisdom is "wonderful in counsel and excellent in working"
- How President Bingham applies these principles:  See slides

Isaiah 29 — Destruction and Restoration

Basic Outline

- **29:1–10** = Destruction of Ariel (Jerusalem): besieged, distressed, brought low, given a spirit of deep sleep
- **29:11–12** = The sealed book: neither the learned nor the unlearned can read it
- **29:13** = Root cause: the people's hearts are far from God — lip service only
- **29:14–16** = The Lord will do a marvelous work; those who try to hide from God are foolish
- **29:17–24** = Restoration: Lebanon becomes a fruitful field, deaf hear, blind see, the meek rejoice, the terrible ones are cut off

29:1–10 — Ariel

- Who this prophecy is about: Jerusalem and its inhabitants — specifically those who celebrate feasts but whose hearts are far from God
- What "Ariel" means and refers to (Cloward): *Ariel* = "altar hearth" (the burning place of sacrifice on the altar) or possibly "lion of God"; it refers to Jerusalem, and specifically to the altar of burnt offering in the temple

- Why "Ariel" is an appropriate symbol for the time of destruction: Jerusalem, which was the place of sacrifice and sacred fire, will itself become a great altar hearth — the city will burn; the sacrificial imagery is inverted; Jerusalem is consumed as if it were the sacrifice
- What "a voice from the dust" / "familiar spirit" means literally in Hebrew: *Ob* = a ghost or medium; literally "a whisper from the ground" — the voice of the dead speaking in a murmur; Jerusalem will be so utterly brought down that its voice will come only as a whisper from the dust
- What the image of a "sealed book" refers to: The spiritual condition of Jerusalem's people — the word of God is as a sealed book to them; they cannot perceive it because their hearts are far from God; they are spiritually blinded
- When Jerusalem became as "an altar hearth" (burned to destruction): **586 BC** — when Nebuchadnezzar burned Jerusalem and the temple
- Five metaphors of Jerusalem at the time:
 1. Ariel — altar hearth/place of burning
 2. Like a dream or vision of the night — insubstantial, fleeting
 3. A voice from the dust / familiar spirit — brought utterly low, whispering
 4. A drunken man staggering — given a spirit of deep sleep, unable to perceive reality
 5. A sealed book — spiritually blind, the word inaccessible to them

Isaiah 29:13

- Meaning: "This people draw near me with their mouth and with their lips do honour me, but have removed their heart far from me, and their fear toward me is taught by the precept of men" — formal, external religion without genuine conversion; hypocrisy and empty ritual
- Two other times this verse appears in scripture:
 1. **Matthew 15:8–9 / Mark 7:6–7** — Jesus quotes this verse to rebuke the Pharisees for honoring God with their lips while their hearts are far from him
 2. **Joseph Smith — History 1:19** — The Lord quotes this verse to Joseph Smith as the reason none of the existing churches are correct: "they draw near to me with their lips, but their hearts are far from me"

Isaiah 29:14 / 29:22–24

- What 29:14 means for Israel: The Lord will proceed to do a "marvellous work and a wonder" among them — the wisdom of the wise shall perish and the understanding of the prudent shall be hidden; God's ways will confound human wisdom; this points to the Restoration
- What will happen to Israel (29:22–24): Jacob shall not be ashamed; his children will sanctify the Holy One of Jacob; they that erred in spirit shall come to understanding; they that murmured shall learn doctrine — a complete spiritual restoration and transformation

2 Nephi 27 — Likening Isaiah 29 to the Book of Mormon

Passage	Question	Answer
27:1–5	What is the "deep sleep"?	The spiritual apostasy of the last days — the Gentiles are in a state of spiritual blindness; the comparable "deep sleep" to that of Jerusalem in Isaiah's day
27:6–8	What is the sealed book (part 1)?	The gold plates of Mormon — specifically the portion that is sealed; delivered to Joseph Smith

27:9–11	What is the sealed book (part 2)?	The sealed portion contains the vision of the brother of Jared and other sacred things; it will not come forth until the people have sufficient faith
27:12–14	Who are the three witnesses?	The Three Witnesses of the Book of Mormon — Oliver Cowdery, David Whitmer, Martin Harris; they will testify of the book to the world
27:15–17	Who is the book delivered to? Who is "another"? Who is "the learned"? What is the meaning of the "sealed book"? How is it sealed?	The book (or a copy of some characters) is delivered to "the learned" = Charles Anthon (who cannot read it because it is sealed, i.e., divinely protected); "another" = Joseph Smith (the unlearned); the book is sealed both physically (a portion of the plates is sealed shut) and spiritually (by the power of God — it can only be translated by divine gift)
27:18–20	What shall the learned and the unlearned say?	The learned says "I cannot read a sealed book" (Anthon's reported response); the unlearned says "I am not learned" (Joseph's humility) — both mirroring the JS-History 1:63–65 account
27:25–29	What is the marvelous work and a wonder? Who will hear the words of the book?	The Restoration of the gospel — the coming forth of the BOM, the Lord confounding human wisdom, restoring truth; the poor, the humble, the meek shall hear the words of the book and rejoice

SG #14 — Isaiah 30–35

Historical Background

- Who was Hezekiah: One of the most righteous kings of Judah; reigned c. 715–686 BC; trusted deeply in the Lord; reformed worship by removing high places, idols, and the bronze serpent (Nehushtan); prepared Jerusalem for Assyrian siege; the only Judean king compared favorably with David
- Situation in Judah 735–701: After Ahaz allied with Assyria (against Isaiah's counsel), Judah became an Assyrian vassal; when Sargon II died (705 BC), Hezekiah joined a coalition rebellion, looking to Egypt for support; Sennacherib responded with his devastating 701 BC campaign
- Rise of the Assyrian empire: Tiglath-Pileser III (745–727), Shalmaneser V (727–722), Sargon II (722–705), and Sennacherib (705–681) — successive kings who expanded Assyrian power across the Near East, destroying the Northern Kingdom in 722
- Why going to Egypt for aid would be tempting: Egypt was the only regional power capable of resisting Assyria; it seemed rational geopolitics; Isaiah condemned it as trusting in "the arm of flesh" rather than the Lord — Egypt is "flesh, not spirit" (31:3) and would ultimately fail them

Theme 1 — Trust in the Lord, Not Egypt (30:1–2; 31:1–3)

- Why Israel should trust the Lord and not Egypt: Because Egypt is human power — flesh, not spirit; when Assyria comes against Egypt and Judah, both will fail and fall together; the Lord alone can truly deliver; furthermore, going to Egypt was done without seeking the Lord's counsel, adding sin upon sin
- Theme 2 — Follow the Word of the Lord (30:8–11; 30:15–19)

- What the people want to hear: "Smooth things" — comfortable prophecies that flatter rather than warn; "speak unto us smooth things, prophesy deceits"; they do not want to hear about the Holy One of Israel
 - Blessings for following the Lord (30:15–19): "In returning and rest shall ye be saved; in quietness and confidence shall be your strength"; the Lord is gracious; he will be very gracious when you cry; he will answer; your eyes shall see your Teacher; a Teacher will no longer be hidden
- World in Front of the Text — Trusting in the Lord vs. the "Arm of Flesh"

- 2 Ne. 4:34 / Jer. 17:5, 7: "Cursed be the man that trusteth in man, and maketh flesh his arm" (Jer 17:5); "Blessed is the man that trusteth in the Lord" (17:7); Nephi — "O Lord, I will not put my trust in the arm of flesh" (2 Ne 4:34) — trusting in human strength, human wisdom, or human alliances instead of in God
- Elder Scott, Perry, Ballard, Romney, Wirthlin — relationship between trusting the Lord and self-reliance:  See slides — general principle from these brethren: true self-reliance is not independence from God but developing the capacity to act under God's direction; trusting in the Lord doesn't mean passivity but faithful action aligned with divine guidance
- Elder McConkie on the brother of Jared and the barges:  See slides — the brother of Jared exercised his own agency, thought out solutions, and brought them to the Lord; he didn't wait for God to do everything; the Lord honored his faithful effort; this models the balance between human agency and divine inspiration

Theme 3 — Blessings and Judgment

Isaiah 33:17–24 — What Zion Will Be Like

- Description of Zion: The people will see the King (the Lord) in his beauty; they will behold a far country; it will be a place of quiet habitation, a tabernacle that cannot be taken down, whose stakes cannot be removed; the Lord will be its judge, lawgiver, king, and savior
- Meaning of the image of the tabernacle and its stakes: The tabernacle = the Church/Zion as a portable, expanding dwelling place of God; the stakes are the supporting pegs that hold it firm; as Zion grows, more stakes are added, the cords lengthen — but none will fail; the image of protective expansion (cf. Isa 54:2; D&C 82:14)

Theme 4 — Eschatological Vision

Isaiah 34:4–6 — Images of Destruction

- Heavens rolled as a scroll: The dissolution of the current cosmic order at the Last Day — like a scroll being rolled up; creation itself is undone (cf. Rev 6:14; D&C 88:95)
- Judgment on Idumea (D&C 1:36): Edom/Idumea historically = the nation descended from Esau, longtime enemy of Israel; in the Lord's usage (D&C 1:36), Idumea = the world — the judgment on Idumea is the judgment on all worldly civilization
- **34:11** — *Tohu wa-bohu*: The Hebrew phrase from Genesis 1:2 meaning "formless and void/chaos" — the condition of the earth before God organized it; Isaiah uses it to describe post-judgment desolation as a reversal of creation, a return to pre-creation chaos; the world is "uncreated" by divine judgment

Isaiah 35:1–10 — Images of Restoration

- Desert blossoms as a rose: The transformation of barren/cursed land to abundance — the earth restored to paradisiacal glory; also spiritual: the spiritually barren are made fruitful
- Eyes of the blind / ears of the deaf opened: (1) Literally fulfilled in Christ's ministry (Matt 11:5; Luke 7:22); (2) Spiritually — the gospel opens the eyes of those in spiritual blindness; (3) Millennial — the physical and spiritual healing of all people in the new creation
- Way of holiness — three possible meanings:
 1. The literal road of return from Babylonian exile — the physical highway home for Jewish exiles
 2. The covenant path of the gospel — the way of Christ, the straight and narrow path; "the unclean shall not pass over it"
 3. The highway of the Millennium — when the ransomed of the Lord return to Zion in the last days with everlasting joy
- Ransomed of the Lord: Those redeemed from sin and death through Christ's Atonement; they return to Zion "with songs and everlasting joy upon their heads"; sorrow and sighing shall flee away

SG #15 — Isaiah 36–39 // 2 Kings 18–20

Key Dates

Date	Event
722	Assyria destroys Samaria/Northern Kingdom; 10 tribes scattered
705	Death of Sargon II; Hezekiah joins coalition revolt against Assyria
701	Sennacherib invades Judah; siege of Jerusalem; miraculous deliverance

Historical Background

- What happened in 722: Shalmaneser V (and Sargon II) destroyed Samaria; the Northern Kingdom fell and its population was deported and replaced — the "lost ten tribes"
- Assyrian king under Ahaz: Tiglath-Pileser III (who Ahaz invited in against Rezin and Pekah)
- Assyrian king who invaded Judah under Hezekiah: **Sennacherib**

Hezekiah

- What kind of king: "He trusted in the Lord God of Israel; so that after him was none like him among all the kings of Judah, nor any that were before him" (2 Kgs 18:5); faithful, reforming, prayerful
- Relationship to Isaiah: Very close; Isaiah was his trusted prophetic counselor; they worked together — Isaiah ministered to him during his illness (ch 38) and counseled him through the Assyrian crisis (ch 36–37)
- Reforms of Hezekiah: Removed high places and idol pillars; cut down the Asherah; broke the bronze serpent (Nehushtan) that had become an object of worship; centralized all worship in Jerusalem; reinstated the Passover with great celebration; reopened and cleansed the temple; what he was trying to accomplish: purify Israel's worship, renew the covenant with the Lord, and restore the Davidic ideal of faithfulness

Four Stories in Isaiah 36–39 (Why Out of Order — Ludlow, p. 328)

Story	Chapter	Summary
#1	38:1–8	Hezekiah's illness, prayer, healing, and 15 added years

#2	39:1–8	Babylonian envoy, Hezekiah's pride, Isaiah's prophecy of Babylonian exile
#3	36	Assyrian invasion; Rabshakeh's speech; Hezekiah's distress
#4	37	Hezekiah's prayer; Isaiah's prophecy; the angel strikes 185,000; Sennacherib's death

- Why they are out of order: Stories #1 (illness) and #2 (Babylonian envoy) are chronologically earlier but placed *after* the Assyrian crisis in the text — likely because they bridge from the Assyrian period to the Babylonian context of Isaiah 40+; the Babylonian envoy story (ch 39) foreshadows the exile that ch 40 then addresses with comfort 📌 See Ludlow p. 328 for specific argument

Story #1 — Isaiah 38:1–8 — Hezekiah's Illness

- The story: Hezekiah fell sick unto death; Isaiah told him to set his house in order for he would die
- His prayer and the Lord's intervention: Hezekiah wept and prayed, reminding the Lord of his faithfulness; before Isaiah had left the middle court, the Lord sent him back with a message of healing
- Sign of the promise / added fifteen years: The shadow on the sundial of Ahaz went *backward* ten steps (or degrees) — a reversal of time as a sign confirming the Lord's promise; Hezekiah was promised 15 more years of life and deliverance from Assyria

Story #2 — Isaiah 39:1–8 — Babylonian Envoy

- Merodach-baladan and Hezekiah: Merodach-baladan (Marduk-apla-iddina), a Babylonian prince who had revolted against Assyria, sent envoys with letters and a gift congratulating Hezekiah on his recovery; Hezekiah naively showed them everything — all the treasures of his house, the armory, everything
- Isaiah's response / the Lord's prophecy: Isaiah asked Hezekiah what the visitors had seen; then pronounced that all that Hezekiah had shown them — and even his own sons — would be carried to Babylon; nothing would be left
- Hezekiah's response: "Good is the word of the Lord which thou hast spoken" — a seemingly passive acceptance of the judgment, with a note of relief that it wouldn't happen in his own days; interpreted by some as faith, by others as selfishness
- What future event this foreshadows: The **Babylonian exile of Judah** (586 BC)
- How it relates to Isaiah 40: Chapter 39 ends with the prophecy of Babylonian captivity; chapter 40 opens with "Comfort ye, comfort ye my people" — the literary bridge is intentional: now that exile has been announced, comfort for the exiles begins

Story #3 — Isaiah 36 — Assyrian Invasion

- Why Hezekiah revolted: The death of Sargon II in 705 BC created an opportunity; Hezekiah joined a Philistine-led coalition with Egyptian backing hoping to throw off Assyrian vassalage
- Two specific preparations for invasion (2 Chron. 32 + ppt):
 1. Hezekiah's Tunnel (the Siloam Tunnel) — diverted the Gihon Spring inside the city walls to secure Jerusalem's water supply during a siege
 2. Repaired and reinforced Jerusalem's walls, built additional fortifications, and created weapons and shields
- Assyrian king and why he came: **Sennacherib** came because Hezekiah had rebelled against him and stopped paying tribute; he considered it his right as suzerain to punish his vassal
- How many cities destroyed before Jerusalem: Sennacherib claims **46** fortified cities of Judah (from the Sennacherib Prism)

- How Assyrian and biblical records match/differ: Both confirm the invasion, Hezekiah's tribute payment, and that Sennacherib besieged but did not take Jerusalem; the Sennacherib Prism says he shut Hezekiah up "like a bird in a cage" but conspicuously never claims to have captured Jerusalem or Hezekiah — consistent with the biblical account of the miraculous deliverance
- The **Lachish reliefs**: A series of carved stone bas-relief panels from Sennacherib's palace at Nineveh depicting in extraordinary detail the Assyrian siege and conquest of the city of Lachish; now in the British Museum; among the most detailed biblical-era archaeological finds
- The **Sennacherib Prism** (Taylor Prism): A hexagonal clay prism recording Sennacherib's military campaigns, including his third campaign against Judah; corroborates the biblical account with some differences
- Where Sennacherib depicted the siege of Lachish: In a large room in his palace at Nineveh — the entire room was decorated with the Lachish siege panels, showing how significant this conquest was to him (perhaps because he couldn't boast of taking Jerusalem)
- What an Assyrian siege was like / how they fought / treated captives: Built elaborate siege ramps, used battering rams and archers, advanced with shields; treatment of conquered peoples was brutal and deliberate — public impalements, flaying of leaders, mass deportation, forced labor — all designed to terrorize other cities into surrender
- **36:4–10, 13–22 — Speech of Rabshakeh** (the Assyrian field commander):
 1. Evidence Judah shouldn't trust Hezekiah or the Lord: He argues Hezekiah removed the Lord's high places, so the Lord is angry; he claims the Lord himself told Assyria to destroy Judah; no nation's god has saved it from Assyria
 2. What he suggests: Surrender and receive good treatment — each man under his own vine and fig tree — then be taken to a good land; don't let Hezekiah deceive you
 3. Blasphemous claims: Compares Jehovah to the defeated gods of Hamath, Arpad, Sepharvaim, Samaria; implies Jehovah is just another powerless national deity; denies Jehovah's uniqueness and sovereignty
 4. Language: He spoke first in **Hebrew** (Judahite/Aramaic was the diplomatic language; the officials asked him to speak in Aramaic so the people on the wall couldn't hear; he deliberately refused and continued in Hebrew to demoralize the people)

Story #4 — Isaiah 37 — Deliverance

- **37:1, 15, 17, 18, 20, 33–35** — Basis of Hezekiah's prayer: He spread Sennacherib's letter before the Lord; acknowledged the Lord's sovereignty as God of all kingdoms; admitted Assyria had destroyed other nations and their gods — but argued those were wood and stone, not true gods; asked for deliverance "that all the kingdoms of the earth may know that thou art the Lord God, even thou only"
- Why the Lord protected Jerusalem: For his own sake and for the sake of his servant **David** — covenant faithfulness to the Davidic promise; not because Judah deserved it but because of the Lord's prior covenant commitment
- Why Hezekiah paid money to Assyria: Before the main siege/confrontation, Hezekiah attempted to appease Sennacherib by sending heavy tribute — silver and gold stripped from the temple — as a vassal acknowledging fault (2 Kgs 18:14–16); the tribute didn't satisfy Sennacherib who still sent Rabshakeh
- Result in the eyes of the people: Profound vindication of Isaiah's prophecies and of trust in the Lord; the inviolability of Jerusalem (the "Zion theology") was confirmed; this belief became so strong it later contributed to false confidence before the Babylonian destruction
- **37:36** — What happened: The **angel of the Lord** smote 185,000 Assyrian soldiers in their camp in a single night; Sennacherib arose to find his army dead; he returned to Nineveh where he was later assassinated by his sons Adrammelech and Sharezer as he worshipped in the temple of his god Nisroch
- Why: The Lord kept his covenant promise to defend Jerusalem; Sennacherib had blasphemed the Lord and threatened his covenant people

- Elder Holland on "**Fear not, for they that be with us are more than they that be with them**" (from Elisha's context in 2 Kgs 6:16):  See slides for exact interpretation — general: Elder Holland teaches that this phrase invites us to see with spiritual eyes the unseen divine help surrounding us; we are never truly alone or outnumbered when we are on the Lord's side SG #16 — Isaiah 40–42

Historical Context

Date	Event
722	Assyria destroys Northern Kingdom; 10 tribes scattered
701	Sennacherib invades Judah; Jerusalem miraculously delivered
605	Nebuchadnezzar defeats Egypt at Carchemish; Babylon dominant
586	Babylon destroys Jerusalem; major deportation of Judah to Babylon
539	Cyrus the Great conquers Babylon; issues decree allowing return

- How the world has politically changed by chapter 40: **Persia is now the major world power** — Assyria has fallen, Babylon is about to fall to Cyrus; Judah has been destroyed and is in Babylonian exile
- Roles of key figures:
 - Nebuchadnezzar**: Babylonian king who destroyed Jerusalem and took Judah captive (605, 597, 586 BC)
 - Manasseh**: Hezekiah's wicked son; long reign (55 years); reversed all of Hezekiah's reforms; filled Jerusalem with idolatry and innocent blood; his reign is often seen as the cause of the Babylonian judgment
 - Josiah**: Great reforming king who found the Book of the Law; purged idolatry; held the greatest Passover since the time of the judges; tragically killed at Megiddo (609 BC) by Pharaoh Necho
 - Zedekiah**: Last king of Judah; put on the throne by Nebuchadnezzar; eventually rebelled; witnessed the fall of Jerusalem; had his sons killed before him, then was blinded and taken to Babylon
 - Jeremiah**: Prophet during the fall of Jerusalem; called the people to surrender to Babylon as God's judgment; endured imprisonment; remained in Jerusalem after the destruction
 - Lehi**: Prophet who left Jerusalem around 600 BC (just before the final Babylonian campaign) with his family — the Lehi record begins here
 - Cyrus**: Persian king who conquered Babylon in 539 BC; named by Isaiah over 150 years before his birth; released the Jewish exiles and funded temple reconstruction
- The two exiles: (1) First deportation — 597 BC, when Jehoiachin and leading citizens (including Ezekiel) were taken; (2) Major destruction and deportation — 586 BC, when Jerusalem and the temple were burned and most of the remaining population was deported
- Four questions Judah asks (addressed by Isaiah 40–48):
 - Why did God allow this to happen?
 - Does God have the power to redeem us?
 - What is our relationship with God?
 - When will we return to rebuild Jerusalem?
- Themes of Isaiah 40–48: **Christ** — the coming of the Messiah and his redemptive work; also divine comfort, the Lord as Creator and Redeemer, the Servant, the new exodus from Babylon, Jehovah's uniqueness vs. idols, Cyrus as the Lord's instrument

Isaiah 40:1–2 — "Comfort Ye"

- Four possibilities for who is being addressed: (1) Members of the **heavenly council** (divine beings commanded to comfort); (2) **Prophets** commissioned to speak comfort; (3) The **leaders/shepherds** of Israel; (4) The **exiles themselves** who are to comfort one another
- The heavenly council (*sod*): The divine assembly where the Lord deliberates with heavenly beings; prophets (in the biblical tradition) are those who have been admitted to this council and hear its decisions; (1 Kgs 22:19 — Micaiah sees the Lord on his throne with the host of heaven; Jer 23:22 — true prophets have stood in the council; Ps 82 — God presides in the divine assembly; Amos 3:7 — the Lord reveals his secrets to his servants the prophets)

Isaiah 40:3–5 — Three Fulfillments

1. **Fulfilled by Cyrus:** The physical return of the Jewish exiles from Babylon — a highway through the wilderness, valleys lifted and mountains leveled for the returning people; fulfilled around 538–515 BC
2. **Fulfilled by Jesus:** John the Baptist explicitly applied this verse to himself as the one preparing the way for Christ (Matt 3:3; John 1:23); the spiritual preparation for the Messiah's first coming
3. **Fulfilled by the Restoration:** The Restoration of the gospel prepares the way for the Second Coming; missionary work and the establishment of Zion create a spiritual highway; the gathering of Israel is the great preparatory work (cf. D&C 65:1)

Isaiah 40:9; 52:7 — "Good Tidings"

- Meaning of the word: Hebrew *basar* (verb: to bring good news) / *besorah* (noun: good news); Greek equivalent = *euangelion* = **gospel**; it was originally used of a messenger bringing news of victory or salvation
- Relates to Jesus: The gospel IS the "good tidings of great joy" (Luke 2:10); Jesus literally brings the good news = he IS the euangelion; the herald announcing "your God reigneth" is ultimately the Messiah himself

Isaiah 40:11 — The Good Shepherd

- OT implications: The Lord as shepherd caring for Israel — imagery from Psalm 23, Ezekiel 34 (the Lord as the good shepherd vs. the false shepherds who have scattered the flock); the tender image of carrying lambs in his bosom and gently leading nursing ewes
- NT implications: Jesus as the Good Shepherd (John 10) — "I am the good shepherd"; he knows his sheep by name; he lays down his life for the sheep; he feeds, guides, protects; cf. also 1 Pet 2:25; Heb 13:20

Isaiah 40:12–31 — God as Creator

- Meaning of the emphasis on God as Creator: The God who measured the waters in the hollow of his hand and weighed the mountains is the same God who promises to comfort the exiles; if he created the cosmos, he can certainly save his people; the argument counters both Babylonian religion (which attributed power to nature gods) and Israelite despair; the Creator has the power to RE-create and redeem

Isaiah 41:8–9 — The Servant

- Meaning of the servant: Israel collectively as the Lord's chosen instrument; also used for specific individuals; the "servant" is chosen, called, and sustained by the Lord to accomplish his purposes
- At least six characteristics of the servant:
 1. Chosen by God — "I have chosen thee"
 2. Descended from Abraham — "the seed of Abraham my friend"
 3. Called/taken from the ends of the earth
 4. Not cast away — "I have not cast thee away"
 5. Strengthened and helped by the Lord
 6. Upheld by the Lord's right hand — sustained in the task

- **41:2** — "Man from the east": Most likely **Cyrus the Great** of Persia (who came from the east relative to Babylon); also possibly Abraham (who came from the east); contextually Cyrus fits best with the military/political action described

Isaiah 42:1–2 — The Servant

- Who is identified as the servant: Matthew 12:17–21 explicitly identifies this passage with **Jesus Christ**; "Behold my servant, whom I uphold; mine elect, in whom my soul delighteth; I have put my spirit upon him" — language of divine sonship and mission
- Role of the servant: Bring forth judgment/justice (*mishpat*) to the Gentiles; not crying loudly in the streets; not breaking the bruised reed or quenching the smoking flax — a gentle, redemptive ministry; establishing justice in the earth
- Seven possible identifications of the servant:
 1. **Israel collectively** — the nation called to be a witness
 2. **Isaiah** — prophet who modeled the servant role
 3. **Cyrus** — political deliverer who accomplished the Lord's purposes
 4. **Zerubbabel** — leader of the return from exile
 5. **Jesus Christ** — the ultimate and primary fulfillment (NT explicitly)
 6. **Joseph Smith** — latter-day servant called to restore
 7. **Any faithful servant of the Lord** — the role is pattern-setting and can apply to all disciples
- How this role can be likened unto us: We are each called to be servants — to bring good tidings, to serve with gentleness, to not break the bruised reed; Elder Uchtdorf's point about being the Lord's hands applies here

World in Front — Elder Uchtdorf

- Two quotes from the Uchtdorf talk:  *See slides for exact quotes*
- How we are "the hands of the Savior": We are instruments through whom Christ's healing, nurturing, and gathering work is performed in the world; we minister, serve, and care for others in a way that extends his work

Authorship of Isaiah

- Where biblical scholars divide: **First Isaiah** = chapters 1–39 (8th century, Assyrian period); **Second Isaiah** = chapters 40–55 (6th century, Babylonian exile); **Third Isaiah** = chapters 56–66 (post-exilic, Persian period); the main division is at chapter 40
- Reasoning for multiple authorship:
 - Historical setting: Chapters 1–39 address the Assyrian crisis of the 8th century; chapters 40–55 presuppose the Babylonian exile (6th century) as already underway — addressing the exiles in Babylon, naming Cyrus, announcing the return
 - Style, form, vocabulary, theology: Different vocabulary clusters, different theological emphases (creation theology, universalism in 40–55), different literary forms (trial speeches, hymns); broader, more lyrical style in 40–55
- Why single authorship matters for the BOM: Lehi left Jerusalem around **600 BC**; if chapters 40–55 weren't written until after 586 BC, they couldn't have been on the Brass Plates; since the Book of Mormon quotes "Second Isaiah" passages, critics argue the BOM is anachronistic
- How a single-authorship argument handles this: Isaiah was a true prophet who could foretell the future (*prophetic foreknowledge*); the differences in style and historical setting reflect the subject matter (Isaiah addressing future exiles as if present) and different phases of ministry, not different authors; ancient sources never divide Isaiah into multiple books
- The claim of the Brass Plates: They contain the writings of Isaiah up to 600 BC, supporting the claim that all Isaiah was written by the 8th century prophet; the BOM's inclusion of "Second Isaiah" material is evidence of the Brass Plates' completeness

- Why "Prophetic Foreknowledge" is key (pp. 153–154): The entire argument for multiple authorship rests on the assumption that true prophecy of specific future events (like naming Cyrus 150 years ahead) is impossible; if prophetic foreknowledge is real — as LDS theology affirms — then the historical argument for multiple authorship collapses; Isaiah naming Cyrus is not evidence against his authorship but *evidence of his prophetic power*
- Recent claims in favor of single authorship: The **Dead Sea Scrolls** great Isaiah scroll contains all 66 chapters in one continuous text with no break at chapter 40; no ancient source ever speaks of more than one Isaiah; Jesus and NT writers quote from both halves and attribute both to Isaiah (e.g., John 12:38–41); recent computational linguistic studies have found patterns supporting unified authorship

SG #17 — Isaiah 43–45

Key Dates

Date	Event
722	Assyria scatters Northern Kingdom
600	Lehi departs Jerusalem
586	Babylon destroys Jerusalem; Judah exiled
539	Cyrus conquers Babylon; issues decree for Jews to return
515	Second Temple completed in Jerusalem

Isaiah 44:28–45:3, 13 — Cyrus the Great

- Who Cyrus was: Founder of the **Achaemenid Persian Empire**; conquered Babylon in 539 BC; ruled from 559–530 BC
- What he did: Released all captive peoples held by Babylon, allowing them to return to their homelands and rebuild their temples; specifically commanded the Jews to return to Jerusalem and rebuild the temple
- Why the Lord considered him a Servant and an *anointed one* (= Messiah): He fulfilled God's purposes perfectly; remarkably, "Messiah" (Hebrew *mashiach* = anointed one) is applied to Cyrus in 45:1 — the only non-Israelite in the entire OT given this title; he was the Lord's chosen instrument for liberation
- What he commanded the Jews to do: Return to Jerusalem and rebuild the temple — "He shall build my city, and he shall let go my captives" (45:13); fulfilled in Ezra 1
- **Cyrus Cylinder**: A clay barrel cylinder (c. 539 BC) inscribed in Babylonian cuneiform recording Cyrus's policy of releasing captive peoples and restoring their religious worship; it confirms the biblical account of Cyrus's benevolent policy; now in the British Museum; called the "first declaration of human rights" by some

Scattering and Gathering — Three Elements

Group	Land	Identity	Christ
10 Tribes	Scattered from Israel/Samaria 722 BC; to be gathered to their own lands	Lost their identity as Israel among the nations; to be restored	Will accept Christ as part of the restoration
Lehites	Brought to the promised land (Americas) by the Lord	Preserved through the Book of Mormon record	Central testimony of the BOM is that Jesus is the Christ
Judah	Scattered (586 BC, AD 70); returning to Israel in the latter days	Preserved Jewish identity through Torah observance	Will accept Christ at the Second Coming (Zech 12:10)

- Strategy of gathering Israel in the Restoration: Missionary work carrying the gospel to all nations; the Book of Mormon as the primary instrument for the Lamanites; the restoration of Judah to their land; the building of Zion and stakes as gathering places

Isaiah 43 — Israel as Servant / Witnesses

- How Israel is a servant: They were created and formed by the Lord for his purposes — to be his witnesses; to declare his salvation to the nations; "this people have I formed for myself; they shall shew forth my praise" (43:21)
- Who the witnesses are and what they are to witness to: The covenant people of Israel are called as witnesses that the Lord alone is God — to testify of who he is and what he has done for them in history; they testify through their existence and their declarations
- How Elder Andersen connects gathering of Israel with witnessing:  See slides — general principle: *gathering Israel in the last days IS missionary work; every member is called to be a witness; the gathering happens through testimony-bearing*

Isaiah 43:16–21 — The New Exodus

- How the return from Babylon is a New Exodus: The Lord uses the Exodus language deliberately — "Thus saith the Lord, which maketh a way in the sea, and a path in the mighty waters" — but then says "Remember ye not the former things"; the new deliverance from Babylon will be so great it will overshadow even the Exodus from Egypt; new wilderness path, water in the desert for the people; the Exodus is both pattern and type for the greater redemption

Isaiah 43:22–26 — Repentance

- What Israel is told to repent of: Not calling upon the Lord, not honoring him with sacrifices, not serving him but making him serve their sins; they have wearied him with iniquities; they owe a debt they cannot pay

- **Sanctification** (Elder Christofferson): The ongoing process of becoming holy through the Atonement of Jesus Christ; the purification of one's nature over time; involves consistent effort, the Spirit, and the grace of God 📌 *See slides for exact definition*
- **Justification** (Elder Christofferson): Being declared righteous/innocent before God through the Atonement of Christ; the initial remission of sins; a legal/forensic declaration that one's debt is paid 📌 *See slides for exact definition*

Isaiah 44:8 — Monotheism

- Monotheism: Belief in and worship of **one God only** — all other supposed gods are non-entities
- Polytheism: Belief in and worship of multiple distinct gods
- History of Israel with monotheism and idolatry:
 - First two commandments: "Thou shalt have no other gods before me" / "Thou shalt not make any graven image" — Israel was explicitly commanded to be exclusively devoted to Jehovah
 - God as a "jealous" God: Hebrew *qanna* = zealous; the Lord will not share devotion with other gods; this is not petty jealousy but the appropriate response of a covenant God who has given everything
 - Worship of Baal and Asherah: Throughout the period of the judges and monarchy, Israel repeatedly worshipped the Canaanite storm/fertility god Baal and the goddess Asherah (often as consort to Jehovah); evidence in the archaeological record includes Asherah poles and inscriptions
 - Challenges of idolatry in Babylon: In Babylon, Israel was surrounded by sophisticated worship of Marduk, Bel, Nebo, and other major deities with elaborate temples and rituals; the pressure to assimilate and adopt Babylonian religion was intense

Isaiah 44:9–20 — Idol Makers

- How Isaiah portrays idol makers: With devastating irony — a man cuts down a tree; he uses half to warm himself and cook his food; with the other half he makes a god and falls down worshipping it, saying "Deliver me, for thou art my god"; he cannot see the absurdity because "a deceived heart hath turned him aside"
- Why it is unwise to depend on idols: They cannot speak, move, act, or save; they are made by human hands from natural material; they share the limitations of the material from which they are made; the idol-maker feeds on ashes
- Modern idolatry:
 - Keller: Idolatry = whatever you look to for the meaning, security, and value that only God can provide; whatever you build your identity and significance upon; it could be career, family, money, approval
 - President Kimball: 📌 *See slides — general: "whatever thing a man sets his heart and his trust in most is his god"; in our day includes wealth, education, status, pleasure*
 - Elder Oaks: 📌 *See slides — general: we must not let any earthly thing displace God in our priorities and worship*
- How we fight against tendencies to be disloyal to the Lord first: Regular self-examination; covenant renewal through the sacrament; keeping the commandments about Sabbath and prayer; recognizing the subtle ways we let lesser things become greater in our priorities

Isaiah 43:21; 45:9 — God the Potter / We the Clay

- "He formed Israel for himself"; "Shall the clay say to him that fashioneth it, What makest thou?" — the created has no right to question the Creator's purposes; we were created for his praise and to accomplish his will; when we submit to the Potter's hands (even in suffering), we are shaped into vessels of honor; pride resists the shaping, humility accepts it

Servants — Tasks and Application

- Who the servants are and their tasks: 📌 See slides
- Pres. Linda K. Burton — **Observe and Serve**: 📌 See slides — *general: we are to observe (pay attention to) the needs of those around us and then serve them; this is the pattern of true discipleship*
- Elder Jeffrey Holland — **The Ministry of Angels**: 📌 See slides — *general: Holland teaches that we can be "ministering angels" to one another; the work of angels is often performed through mortal hands; we are called to that angelic ministry*

Josephus on Cyrus (Ludlow, pp. 383–384)

📌 See Ludlow pp. 383–384 — *general: Josephus records (Antiquities XI.1) that Cyrus was shown the prophecy of Isaiah naming him, and that he was moved by the fulfillment of the prophecy to grant the Jews permission to return; this is a remarkable ancient extra-biblical tradition supporting both prophetic foreknowledge and the unity of Isaiah*

SG #18 — Isaiah 46–48

Isaiah 46:1–2 — Babylonian Gods/Idols

- Image of Babylonian gods: **Bel** (= Marduk, the chief Babylonian deity) and **Nebo** (god of writing and wisdom) are depicted being loaded onto pack animals — they are being carried into exile; the contrast is with the Lord who *carries* his people, while these gods must be *carried* by their worshippers
- Where they're going and why: Into captivity with the fall of Babylon (539 BC); they could not save themselves or their city from Cyrus

Isaiah 46:4–5 — Maternal Image of God

- Purpose and value of the maternal image (Elder Holland): 📌 See slides — *general: the Lord says "I have made, and I will bear; even I will carry, and will deliver you" — an image of a mother carrying a child; Holland likely emphasizes that God's love encompasses both fatherly and motherly dimensions of love; unlike the idols that burden their worshippers, God carries us through life*

Isaiah 46:6–10 — Three Ways Lord is Superior

1. He **foretells the future** — "declaring the end from the beginning, and from ancient times the things that are not yet done"; idols cannot do this
2. He **acts in history** to accomplish his purposes — "I will do all my pleasure"; his word does not return void; idols are passive objects
3. He alone is **God** — "I am God, and there is none like me, and none else"; he is without peer or competitor

Isaiah 46:11 — "Ravenous Bird from the East"

- Who this is: **Cyrus the Great** of Persia; his military campaigns swept from the east like a bird of prey; "a man of my counsel from a far country"
- What he will do: Execute God's purpose — conquer Babylon, liberate the exiles, fulfill the Lord's plan

Isaiah 46:12–13 — Zion in the Old Testament

- Meaning of Zion in the OT: Originally the mountain/city of David; extended to mean the city of God — characterized by God's presence, righteousness, and the gathering of his people; the ideal community where the Lord dwells
- How Jerusalem's vision parallels the City of Enoch:

- **Unity:** "They were of one heart and one mind" (Moses 7:18) — Zion is characterized by perfect harmony
- **Righteousness:** No wickedness dwells in Zion; the people are pure in heart
- **Care for the Poor:** "There was no poor among them" (Moses 7:18) — economic justice is essential to Zion
- **Temple:** The place of God's presence and sacred ordinances
- **Salvation:** The Lord's saving work is centralized in Zion
- **Glory:** "The Lord was there" and his glory rested upon the city

D&C 1:16; 133:14 — Destruction of Babylon / the Restoration

- How the destruction of Babylon in 539 BC teaches about the Restoration: The fall of ancient Babylon is a *type* of the fall of "spiritual Babylon" (the world/wickedness) at the Last Day; just as the Lord commanded his people to flee Babylon in Isaiah's day (48:20), the Lord in D&C 133:14 commands "go ye out from Babylon, be ye clean that bear the vessels of the Lord" — the Restoration initiates the spiritual exodus from Babylon that will culminate in the Second Coming

Isaiah 47 — Taunt Over Babylon

- Meaning of a "taunt over Babylon": A *taunt song* (*qinah*) is a mocking lament or funeral dirge sung over a fallen enemy; it celebrates the reversal of Babylon's fortunes with ironic gloating
- **47:1–5** — How Babylon is personified: As a proud **queen/lady** (the "virgin daughter of Babylon") who will be stripped of her royalty and made to sit in the dust; forced to grind meal as a slave; stripped of her veil; exposed — the ultimate humiliation of a once-imperial power
- Characteristics of Babylon:
 - Sister Edmunds:  See slides
 - Elder Christofferson:  See slides — *general: Babylon = the world organized in opposition to God; characterized by pride, materialism, moral corruption, and spiritual blindness*
- Specific ways we must flee Babylon: Separate ourselves from worldly values (materialism, pride, moral relativism, media that degrades); keep the Sabbath; be in but not of the world; keep covenants; build Zion communities
- **Revelation 18** on Babylon: Describes the fall of "Babylon the Great" at the Last Day; merchants and kings who trafficked with her will mourn; the saints are commanded "Come out of her, my people" — the same call as Isaiah 48:20; her judgment comes in one hour

Isaiah 48:1–2, 6 — Book of Mormon Addition

- What addition the Book of Mormon makes and what it means:  See slides and Ludlow pp. 401–402 — *the BOM version of Isa 48:1 adds the phrase "and have come forth out of the waters of Judah, or out of the waters of baptism" (1 Ne 20:1), connecting the identity of Israel to the ordinance of baptism; Ludlow's discussion clarifies the textual and doctrinal significance of this variant*

Isaiah 48 — Exile and Forgiveness

- Why the Lord says Israel was exiled: For their stubbornness and hardness of neck — "I knew that thou wouldest deal very treacherously, and wast called a transgressor from the womb"; because of their sins and spiritual obstinacy
- Why the Lord has forgiven them: For his own name's sake — "For mine own sake, even for mine own sake, will I do it: for how should my name be polluted?" (48:11); not because Israel deserved forgiveness but because of the Lord's own covenant faithfulness and concern for his holy name

Isaiah 48:10 — Furnace of Affliction

- Meaning: The Lord has refined Israel (and us) in the furnace of affliction as silver is purified — trial, suffering, and hardship are the divine refinery that purifies the soul and removes dross

- Used elsewhere in scripture: Deut 4:20 — Egypt described as "the iron furnace"; Jer 11:4 — the covenant given "in the day that I brought them forth out of the land of Egypt, from the iron furnace"; 1 Pet 1:7 — faith "more precious than gold that perisheth, though it be tried with fire"
- How Elder Cook describes this process: 📌 *See slides*
- How Elder Oaks describes this process: 📌 *See slides — general: trials are not evidence of God's absence but of his trust; he tailors our challenges to refine us; suffering accepted in faith leads to spiritual growth*
- How Elder Maxwell describes this process: 📌 *See slides — general: Maxwell frequently taught that our trials are "customized curriculum"; afflictions are designed precisely for us; the furnace purifies; we are not tried beyond what we can bear*
- Application to personal experience: 📌 *Personal — to be filled in by you based on your own life*
- Challenges to faith that trials present: Questioning God's love or existence; anger at apparent injustice; the difficulty of waiting for promised blessings; the temptation to abandon faith when blessings don't come as expected
- Things to remember to maintain faith: God's promises are certain even when delayed; trials have purpose and will end; the Atonement covers suffering as well as sin; we are not alone; eternity gives perspective that mortality cannot

Isaiah 48:20–22

- What the Lord commands Judah to do: "Go ye forth of Babylon, flee ye from the Chaldeans, with a voice of singing declare ye" — leave Babylon, proclaim the redemption of the Lord to all the earth
- Reassurance the Lord gives: He will provide as he did in the wilderness — "He led them through the deserts: he caused the waters to flow out of the rock for them" — the same God who provided in the Exodus will provide again; "There is no peace, saith the Lord, unto the wicked" — but the redeemed will have peace

Elder Christofferson — Babylon and Zion

- Definition of Babylon: 📌 See slides for exact definition — *general: the world in opposition to God; the organized system of pride, materialism, and wickedness*
- Definition of Zion: 📌 See slides for exact definition — *general: the pure in heart; the people and community organized around God*
- Three elements of the City of Enoch and how they apply to our day:
 1. **The Lord dwelt there** — we build his presence into our communities through temples, ordinances, and righteousness
 2. **One heart and one mind** — we pursue unity in doctrine, purpose, and care for one another
 3. **No poor among them** — we care for the poor through consecration, fast offerings, and welfare; economic justice is essential to Zion

Hymns Reflecting Isaiah and the Values of Zion

Hymn	Connection to Isaiah / Zion Values
<i>Ye Elders of Israel</i>	Reflects the call to gather Israel from the four corners of the earth; missionaries as the "swift messengers" of Isaiah 18; the gathering imagery of Isaiah 40–48
<i>Sisters in Zion</i>	Reflects the nurturing/maternal imagery of Isaiah 46 and 66; women's essential role in building Zion; connects to the comfort and caring language of Isaiah 40
<i>Israel, Israel, God Is Calling</i>	Directly echoes Isaiah's call to flee Babylon — "Come to Zion, come to Zion"; the command of Isaiah 48:20 to "go forth from Babylon"; the gathering of Israel as the great last-days work